Cast of Characters

Jalaluddin Muhammad Akbar: Third Mughal emperor. Ruled for just short of fifty years (1556–1605) and built the empire that bears his dynasty's name

Family

Babur: Akbar's grandfather. Ruled in Fergana, Kabul and – very briefly – Agra, where he laid the foundations of his family's ambitions in Hindustan

Maham Begum: Babur's wife, Humayun's mother (not to be confused with Maham Anaka, Akbar's nurse)

Khanzada: Babur's sister and trusted adviser to all four of his sons

Haider: Babur's cousin, Humayun's uncle. Commander and adviser in Humayun's court. Left to conquer Kashmir after Humayun's exile from Hindustan. Wrote a history of the Moghuls of Central Asia, the *Tarikh-i Rashidi*

Humayun: Babur's eldest son, Akbar's father. Lost Hindustan to Sher Shah Suri. Managed to reclaim his throne but died only months afterwards, leaving thirteen-year-old Akbar to inherit his conquest-in-progress

Hamida: Akbar's mother. Married Humayun, with reluctance, during his exile. Had Akbar when she was about sixteen and lived almost to the very end of his life and reign. Was deeply loved, respected and trusted by her son

Muazzam: Hamida's brother and Akbar's uncle. Eccentric, unreliable and increasingly violent, was eventually imprisoned by Akbar

Kamran: Akbar's uncle, Humayun's half-brother. Usually the villain in stories of Humayun's life

Askari: Akbar's uncle, Humayun's half-brother, Kamran's full-brother – and his unimpressive second-in-command

Hindal: Akbar's uncle, Humayun's youngest half-brother. Brave, chivalrous and greatly mourned by his sister, Gulbadan

Yadgar Nasir: Humayun's cousin. Plotted against Humayun once too often, executed at Humayun's orders